

construction of a motherboard. External audio cards are those which connect via USB or other similar ports. They are comparatively prone to distortion since the audio has to travel through the USB chip before getting to the platform controller hub.

Sound cards can have a host of connectivity options for speakers and microphones. Common connectors include

- 2.5 mm audio socket
- 3.5 mm audio socket
- 6.35mm TRS socket
- S/PDIF - Electrical or optical
- RCA socket

It is common for a single stereo socket to exist with adaptors provided to switch between sockets. \

What to buy

When shopping for a sound card, remember the following points

1. Isolated power supply helps out a lot in reducing noise from creeping into the sound signal.
2. Depending upon what kind of speaker arrangement you are going for, ensure you have sufficient connectors on the sound card. If not, invest in adaptors to get the job done.
3. Most onboard cards are not capable of driving high impedance headphones that's when you know that you need a sound card.
4. Similarly, having a good sound card and not having good headphones / speakers defeats the purpose of buying the sound card in the first place.

SMPS

The SMPS or the Switching Mode Power Supply is where the computer gets its power from. While it does plug into the AC mains, computer components inherently work on DC voltages ranging from 1.8v to 12v. The SMPS, however, provides 12v, 5v and 3.3v from AC power mains. This is further brought down to various levels as required by the particular component. Now different countries use different voltages as the standard, we have the

